Jain Code of Conduct

Mahavira asked his followers to live a virtuous life. In order to live a life filled with sound morals, he preached five major principles to follow.

They are:

- Ahimsa - not to injure any living beings
- Satya - to speak truth
- Asteya - not to steal
- Aparigraha - not to own property
- Brahmacharya - Celibacy

DO YOU KNOW?

Gautama Swami, a chief disciple of Mahavira, compiled the teachings of Mahavira, called *Agama sidhantha*.

Digambaras and Svetambaras

Jainism split into two sects.

Digambaras

- Digambaras are orthodox and conservative followers.
- Monks of the digambara sect, do not wear any clothing and live naked. They are forbidden to have any kind of possessions.
- Digambaras believe that women cannot achieve nirvana or liberation directly.



Svetambaras

- The Svetambaras are considered progressive.
- Monks of Svetambaras sect, wear white robes. They are permitted to have *Rajoharana* (broom with wollen threads), begging bowl and book.
- Svetambaras believe that women are equally capable of achieving liberation as men.

Reasons for the Spread of Jainism

The following are the main reasons for the wide acceptance of Jainism in India

- Use of people's language.
- Intelligible teachings.
- Support from rulers and traders.
- Perseverance of Jain monks.

Influence of Jainism (Samanam) in Tamil Nadu

- In ancient Tamil literature, Jainism is referred to as Samanam.
- There is a Samanar Hill or Samanar Malai in Keelakuyilkudi village, 15 km away from Madurai. The images of Tirthankaras created by Jain monks are found in the hill. It is a protected monument of Archaeological Survey of India.
- In Arittapatti, a small village 25 km from Madurai, on one side of Kalinjamalai hill there are Jain caves called Pandavar Padukkai. Pandavar Padukkai is the bed of Jain saints.
- There is a reference to Aravor Palli, place of living for Jain monks, in Manimegalai.

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